Serfoji's most striking initiative was the founding and management of free elementary and secondary schools for orphans and the poor in Thanjavur city and other adjacent places. Included were schools for all levels, charity schools, colleges and *padashalas* for Sanskrit higher learning. The schools catered to the court elites, Vedic scholars, orphans and the poor. A second innovation was the introduction of *navavidya* ('modern' or 'new' learning) in the state-run schools.

According to an 1823 report produced for Governor Munro's census of education, 21 of the 44 free schools in the wider Thanjavur district were run by Serfoji's government, 19 by the missionaries, one by a temple. There were three schools that were run by teachers themselves free of cost. In the state-run free schools Serfoji made modern education available to all.

In 1822, at the free school in *Muktambal Chattiram* the king's favourite almshouse established in 1803, 15 teachers taught a total of 464 students of diverse castes, in two classes, in the morning and in the evening. Serfoji also supported a free school for needy Christians, run by missionaries in the village of Kannandangudi.

Serfoji II established *Dhanvantari Mahal*, a research institution that produced herbal medicine for humans and animals. Maintaining case-sheets of patients was introduced.
Physicians of modern medicine, Ayurveda, Unani and Siddha schools undertook research on drugs and herbs for medical cure. They produced eighteen volumes of research material. Serfoji also catalogued the important herbs in the form of exquisite hand paintings.

Serfoji's strategic initiatives in modern education enabled the Thanjavur court elite and subjects to enter and benefit from the emerging colonial social and economic order. The court officials, mostly Brahmins, trained in European knowledge, technologies and arts became leading agents of colonial modernity, equal to the English-educated *dubashe*s, writers and interpreters, both Hindu and Christian, who mediated between the Europeans and Indian courts. Two of Serfoji's pandits (one of them was Kottaiyur Sivakolundu Desigar) joined the Company's College of Fort St.George and became leaders in translation and print culture. The careers and projects of Serfoji and John illuminate the important roles that enterprising individuals, and small places, such as a Danish-Tamil fishing village and a Maratha-Tamil principality, played in the history of change in colonial Tamilnadu.

Serfoji II was a patron of traditional Indian arts like dance and music. He authored *Kumarasambhava Champu*, *Devendra Kuravanji*, and *Mudra rakshaschaya*. He introduced western musical instruments like clarinet, and violin in Carnatic music. He is also credited with popularising the unique Thanjavur style of painting. Serfoji was interested in painting, gardening, coin-collecting, martial arts and patronized chariot-racing, hunting and bull-fighting. He created the first zoological garden in Tamilnadu in the Thanjavur palace premises.

Serfoji II died on 7th March 1832 after almost forty years of his rule. His death was mourned throughout the kingdom and his funeral procession was attended by more than 90, 000 people. At his funeral, Rev. Bishop Heber observed: 'I have seen many crowned heads, but no one whose deportment was more princely'.

SUMMARY

- Shivaji's rise, his military conquests and his encounter with Aurangzeb are dealt with
- Shivaji's administrative reforms are explained
- Shivaji's successors and their achievements under the Peshwas Balaji Viswanath, Baji Rao and Balaji Baji Rao are discussed

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